

Persian, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to Iranian Persian

Adhithya Rajasekaran

Starter edition — eight short chapters, with more being written.

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Preface

This book teaches Persian one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It assumes no Persian and no Perso-Arabic script: every section takes one small expression, introduces only the letters and grammar that expression needs, connects it to words you may already know, and ends by asking for it back. Persian reads right to left — but you will be reading real words long before you have met the whole alphabet.

This is contemporary Iranian Persian. Romanization stays beside the script for now and fades as your reading grows. Where formal written and colloquial forms diverge, both are labelled rather than quietly averaged; Dari and Tajik are relatives of this language, not substitutes for it, and are not smuggled in here.

Persian vocabulary comes in historical layers. Some everyday words are inherited Iranian forms; many others arrived through Arabic and now follow Persian pronunciation and grammar completely. Etymology in this book is practical — it gives a word a handhold in your memory — and never a claim that a borrowed word is less fully Persian today.

This is a starter edition: eight short chapters, complete in themselves, with more being written.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Persian out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

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Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

This chapter builds one miniature exchange in dependency order: greet, thank, answer yes, answer no. Four short expressions are enough to establish the direction of the script, joining, one non-joining letter, omitted short vowels, and the contrast between borrowed and inherited vocabulary.

1.1 سلام (*salâm*) — hello through peace

Read only what this expression needs

Persian runs **right to left**. Read سلام from its right edge: س *s*, ل *l*, ا long *â*, م *m*. Most letters join inside a word. The tall ل is a non-joiner on its left side, so the final م begins a new stroke group. No other letters are required yet.

Where the expression came from

Salâm means “hello” and evokes peace. Persian borrowed it from Arabic, whose consonant family **s-l-m** carries ideas of peace, safety, and wholeness. Hebrew *shalom* belongs to the same older Semitic family. The word is borrowed history and completely ordinary modern Persian at once.

Use it now

Say سلام to one person or a group. It is a neutral, friendly greeting. Hear it, answer with the same word, and resist adding any grammar yet.

One-minute checkpoint

Read سلام from right to left. Which letter carries the long *â*? Point to ل, cover the romanization, and say *salâm* once.

1.2 ممنون (*mamnun*) — thank you**Read only what this expression needs**

Reuse final م from سلام, now at the right edge where reading begins. The visible sequence is م *m*, م *m*, ن *n*, و long *u*, ن *n*. Persian usually omits short vowels, so the first *a* is learned with the whole word. Here و carries the long *u*.

Where the expression came from

Persian received *mamnun* from Arabic. It describes someone as grateful or obliged and belongs to the Arabic **m–n–n** family associated with favor or kindness. In current Persian conversation, the whole word is simply a useful “thanks.”

Use it now

Build the smallest exchange: A says سلام; B answers سلام; A adds ممنون. Treat each expression as one social move.

One-minute checkpoint

Which visible letter carries long *u* in ممنون? Point to و, then say *salâm* — *mamnun* without looking.

1.3 بله (*bale*) — yes**Read only what this expression needs**

Read three letters: ب *b*, ل *l*, ه *h*. The short *a* and *e* are supplied by the reader rather than written as separate letters. The final ه remains visible even though careful speech ends with a light vowel-like sound rather than a forceful English *h*.

Use it now

Bale is a standard polite affirmative. A more casual answer exists, but one reliable “yes” is enough now: *bale*, *mamnun* — yes, thank you.

One-minute checkpoint

Cover *bale*. Read بله; name the two short vowels that the writing leaves implicit; answer “yes” once.

1.4 نه (*na*) — no, and an inherited bridge**Read only what this expression needs**

You already know final ه from بله and ن from ممنون. Put ن on the right and read نه: *n* plus an unwritten short *a*.

Where the expression came from

Unlike the two Arabic loans at the start of this chapter, Persian *na* continues an old Indo-Iranian negative family. Related forms occur across Iranian and Indo-Aryan languages. This is the first bridge from Persian toward Hindi and Urdu: not an instruction to learn those forms now, just a reason the tiny word may feel familiar later.

Use it now

Contrast only the answer: بله *bale* — yes; نه *na* — no. Ask yourself a harmless yes/no question and answer it both ways.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce the four-step chain: hello, thank you, yes, no. Then read سلام, ممنون, بله, نه in the same order.

Chapter 2

Give your name

Modes: ⇄ **voice** (1) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

The first chapter supplied social moves. This one adds a single sentence and a single grammar idea: Persian's linking vowel, *ezafe*.

2.1 اسم من ... است (*esm-e man ... ast*) — my name is ...

Read the Persian phrase from right to left while keeping its spoken word order:

اسم من سارا است
esm-e man Sârâ ast — My name is Sara.

Read only what this expression needs

The phrase reuses more than it appears to. In اسم *esm*, you already recognize ا, س, and م. In من *man*, both letters came from ممنون. The final word است *ast* begins with familiar ا and س; only ت *t* is new. Short vowels remain mostly implicit.

Use it now

Assemble four pieces:

1. اسم *esm* — name;
2. a spoken *-e* — the linker called **ezafe**;
3. من *man* — I/me, interpreted here as the owner;

4. your name, followed by است *ast* — is.

Only one reusable pattern is due: **noun + -e + owner**. Do not expand it into a table of possessive grammar yet.

Where the expression came from

The sentence displays two historical layers side by side. *Esm* is an Arabic loan related to Arabic *ism*. *Man* and *ast* belong to Persian's inherited Iranian core. Borrowed nouns and inherited grammar now work together as one Persian sentence.

One-minute checkpoint

What links *esm* to *man*? Say the normally unwritten *-e*. Then replace Sara with your own name and produce the full careful sentence once.

What is deliberately deferred

Everyday speech often shortens the final copula, and Persian has familiar and polite ways to ask another person's name. Those are later lessons. Keeping the full است visible here lets a new reader account for every part before conversational reductions begin.

Chapter 3

Ask and Answer Names

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone's name respectfully with shomâ, answer with my own, and tell them I am pleased to meet them.

A six-line first meeting: greet, ask the name with respectful shomâ, answer with your own, and acknowledge with khoshvaghtam.

3.1 شما / تو — two relationships inside “you”

Say **esm-e man ... ast** with your own name. To turn that sentence around, you next need a safe word for the other person.

The two words

Persian	read	use
شما	<i>shomâ</i>	one person respectfully, or more than one person
تو	<i>to</i>	one familiar person

In شما, meet ش *sh*; its three dots distinguish it from س *s*. Final ل carries long â. In تو, و has its *o* value rather than the long *u* it had in ممنون. Learn the sound from the whole word.

Grammar Lens: begin respectfully

Persian uses plural **shomâ** for respectful singular address, much as Russian uses *vy* and French uses *vous*. Use **shomâ** with an unfamiliar adult or in a first meeting. Use **to** after the relationship is familiar. English once made a similar distinction but now uses *you* for both.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Persian **to** belongs to the ancient Indo-European familiar-“you” family: English **thou**, Latin *tū*, and Sanskrit *tvam* are relatives. The word is old; the social choice carried by it is current.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a new adult — **shomâ**
- a close friend — **to**
- the old family — **to, thou, tū, tvam**

Before you move on

Which form is safest when the relationship is new? (**Shomâ**.) Which is the relative of English *thou*? (**To**.)

Source: Persian Online: Pronouns.

3.2 چیست — “what is?” in one joined word

Which “you” is safe for a new adult? (شما, *shomâ*.) Now add the question engine that will follow “your name.”

You’ll want to know first — چیست

چیست — *chist* — what is?

Read from the right: چ *ch*, ی long *i*, س *s*, ت *t*. چ is one of Persian’s four additions to the Arabic alphabet: it uses the same base shape as چ, with three dots below. Meet only this joined form now.

Grammar Lens: two words compressed

chist is the careful fusion of **chi** “what” and **ast** “is.” The opening vowel of *ast* disappears when the pieces join:

$$chi + ast \rightarrow \text{chist}$$

You already know full **ast** from *esm-e man ... ast*. This lesson changes no copula rule; it gives one high-frequency fused question form.

Your turn

- Say it: **chi + ast** → **chist**
- Read it: چیست from چ to ت
- Say it: **chist?** — “what is?”

Before you move on

What two pieces make **chist**? (**Chi + ast**.) Which new Persian letter opens it? (چ, *ch*, with three dots below.)

3.3 چیست؟ شما اسم — ask a name respectfully

Give the three ready pieces: **esm-e** “name-of,” **shomâ** respectful “you,” and **chist** “what is?”

The exchange

چيست؟ شما اسم — *esm-e shomâ chist?* — **What is your name?**

The Persian order is transparent once the pieces are known:

name + **-e** + you + what-is?

The spoken ezafe turns **esm-e shomâ** into “your name.” **Chist** stays at the end. No new agreement or verb table is hiding here.

Script: the question mark

Persian ends a written question with ؟. Its curve faces the opposite way from English ?, matching the right-to-left line. Read the sentence from its right edge; meet the punctuation at the far left.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **esm-e shomâ chist?**
- *Say it:* ask, then answer — **esm-e man ... ast**
- *Point to:* to ؟ at the end of the right-to-left question

Before you move on

Ask the question once without reading the romanization. Then answer with the careful name frame you already know.
Source: Persian Online: Introducing Yourself.

3.4 خوشوقتم — pleased to meet you

Ask **esm-e shomâ chist?** and answer **esm-e man ... ast**.
One warm response now closes that tiny meeting.

The exchange

خوشوقتم — *khoshvaghtam* — **Pleased to meet you.**

Treat the joined word as one social move first. خ gives *kh*, like the sound in Scottish *loch*. ش gives *sh*. Persian commonly pronounces ق here with the merged *gh/q* sound of contemporary Iranian speech.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **khosh** — pleasant, happy; inherited Persian vocabulary.
- **vaqt** (pronounced *vaght* here) — time; an Arabic loan fully at home in Persian.
- **-am** — I am, the first-person ending.

So the word builds “pleasant-time-I-am” into the idiomatic feeling “I

am pleased.” The history is layered; the expression is ordinary modern Persian.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **khoshvaghtam** as one smooth response
- the three pieces — **khosh + vaqt + -am**
- which piece came from Arabic — **vaqt**

Before you move on

Which response closes the introduction? (**Khoshvaghtam.**) Which three layers can you hear inside it? (**Khosh + vaqt + -am.**)
Source: Persian Online: Introducing Yourself.

3.5 Practice — a complete Persian name exchange

Recall the four moves without adding anything: greet, ask, answer, acknowledge.

The exchange

A: سلام! — *Salâm!* B: سلام! — *Salâm!* A: چیست؟ شما اسم —
Esm-e shomâ chist? B: است سارا من اسم. — *Esm-e man Sârâ*
ast. A: خوشوقتم. — *Khoshvaghtam.* B: ممنون. — *Mamnun.*

Every line is already known. **Shomâ** keeps the first meeting respectful; the answer returns to **man**. The question mark sits at the left end of the right-to-left question.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both voices, using your own name
- the exchange again without romanization
- only the three name moves — question, answer, response

Before you move on

Run the meeting once from **salâm** to **mamnun**. If one line stalls, review that single micro-lesson rather than rereading the whole chapter.

Chapter 4

How Are You?

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how someone is in careful respectful Persian and answer that I am well, thank you.

The careful wellbeing exchange in two moves: hâl-e shomâ chetor ast? answered khubam, mamnun.

4.1 حال — the “state” in a wellbeing question

Run only the opening of the meeting you know: **salâm** and the name question. The next move asks about the other person’s present state.

You’ll want to know first — one useful word

حال — *hâl* — state, condition

Read from right to left: ح *h* + ا long *â* + ل *l*. The first letter is a breathier *h* than English normally uses; a clear ordinary *h* is a safe beginner approximation. Keep the whole written word attached to its meaning.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Persian borrowed **hâl** from Arabic, then uses it with Persian grammar. You will soon say **hâl-e shomâ**, literally “the state of you.” That **-e** is the same spoken ezafe already learned in **esm-e shomâ**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hâl** — state or condition
- *Read it:* حال from right to left
- *Connect:* an Arabic-rooted noun inside Persian ezafe grammar

Before you move on

What does **hâl** name? (A state or condition.) Which familiar linker will attach an owner to it? (Ezafe **-e**.)
Source: Persian Online: Greetings List.

4.2 چطور — “how?” one layer at a time

Say the Persian noun for a state or condition. (**Hâl**.) Now ask about the manner of that state with one question word.

You’ll want to know first — the question word

چطور؟ — *chetor?* — **how?** / **in what manner?**

You already met چ *ch* in چیست. Here it is followed by ط *t*, و *o*, and ر *r*. The short *e* is not written. Learn the sound from the whole word: *che-tor*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Persian Online takes چطور apart as Persian چه *che*, “what,” plus the Arabic loan طور *tor*, “manner.” The literal picture is “in what manner?” That layered history is useful memory, but **chetor** is one everyday Persian question word now.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **chetor?** — how?
- *Point to:* to familiar چ at the right edge
- *Rebuild:* **che** “what” + **tor** “manner”

Before you move on

Which part means “what”? (**Che.**) Which borrowed part means “manner”? (**Tor.**)

Source: Persian Online: Interrogatives.

4.3 است؟ چطور شما حال — ask “How are you?” respectfully

Recall **hâl** “state,” **shomâ** respectful “you,” **chetor** “how,” and careful **ast** “is.” The only assembly move is familiar ezafe.

The exchange

است؟ چطور شما حال — *hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?* — **How are you?**

Build it without translating English word for word:

state + **-e** + respectful-you + how + is?

The unwritten ezafe in **hâl-e shomâ** works exactly like **esm-e shomâ**. Persian asks, literally, “the state of you, in what manner is?”

Grammar Lens: one reliable careful form

This chapter asks you to produce the careful written form with **ast**. Everyday Iranian speech often contracts the end to *چتوره؟ chetore?*; recognize that preview, but keep the uncontracted line until the careful pattern is secure.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?**
- *Trace it:* **hâl-e shomâ** — state-of-you
- *Choose:* careful production now — final **ast**

Before you move on

Ask once from memory. What already-known grammar holds **hâl** and **shomâ** together? (Ezafe -e.)

Source: Persian Online: Greetings List.

4.4 خوب — “good” and “well”

Ask **hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?** The smallest positive answer begins with one word.

You’ll want to know first — the answer word

خوب — *khub* — good, well

At the right edge, خ is *kh*, made farther back than English *h*. و carries long *u*, as it did in ممنون; final ب closes the word with *b*. Say it as one beat: *khub*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Persian’s everyday vocabulary is layered. **Hâl** and the **tor** inside **chetor** came through Arabic; **khub** belongs to the inherited Persian layer. All three are fully ordinary Persian now. History helps memory without ranking one layer as more authentic than another.

Your turn

- Say it: **khub** — good, well
- Read it: خ + long-*u* و + final ب
- Contrast: inherited **khub** beside borrowed **hâl**

Before you move on

Give the answer word once without romanization. Which letter carries its long *u*? (و.)

Source: Persian Online: Greetings List.

4.5 ممنون خوبم، — “I am well, thank you”

Say **khub** “well,” then the thanks you learned in Chapter 1: **mamnun**. One small ending turns the first word into a full answer.

The exchange

ممنون خوبم، — *Khubam, mamnun*. — **I am well, thank you.**

The new final م is *m*. Attach it directly to خوب: خوب + م → خوبم. Persian script and speech both keep the answer compact.

Grammar Lens: one copula ending, not a table

The attached ending **-am** means “I am” here. Persian Online notes that خوب by itself already means “I am fine”; the separate pronoun **man** is unnecessary. Learn only this useful first-person ending today. The rest of the copula set can arrive one form at a time later.

Your turn

- *Build:* **khub + -am → khubam**
- *Say it:* **khubam, mamnun**
- *Point to:* to final م carrying “I am”

Before you move on

What does final **-am** contribute? (“I am.”) Do you need a separate **man** in this answer? (No.)

Sources: Persian Online: Verb “To Be” and Greetings List.

4.6 Practice — a Persian wellbeing exchange

Recall the two moves only: ask about the other person’s state, then answer “I am well, thank you.”

The exchange

A: سلام! چطور شما حال است؟ *Salâm! Hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?* B:
ممنون خوبم. *Khubam, mamnun.*

Every piece is already owned. The question reuses respectful **shomâ**, ezafe, and careful **ast**. The answer's final **-am** carries "I am," so no new pronoun is hiding between the lines.

Grammar Lens: keep the social choice visible

Use this careful question in a first meeting. You may hear shorter conversational forms, but producing one stable respectful line first prevents script, register, and contraction from arriving as one oversized step.

Your turn

- *Say it:* both voices with the script visible
- *Say it:* both voices without romanization
- *Switch:* ask first, then answer after a pause

Before you move on

Run the exchange once from **salâm** to **mamnun**. If one side stalls, return to that single micro-lesson rather than rereading the chapter.

Chapter 5

Take Leave

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can open a short Persian conversation, check how the other person is, and close it with *khodâ hâfez*.

A four-line interaction with a beginning and an end: salâm, the well-being check, then khodâ hâfez from both voices.

5.1 خدا — the Persian half of a farewell

Run the known wellbeing exchange once. The next chapter adds only the final social move: ending that interaction.

You'll want to know first — one word

خدا — *khodâ* — God

Read from right to left: خ *kh* + د *d* + ا long *â*. The short *o* is learned with the word rather than written as a separate letter. Keep the back-of-the-mouth **kh** gentle; clarity matters more than force.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Modern **khodâ** continues Middle Persian *xwadây*, “lord.” The everyday farewell will pair this inherited Persian word with an Arabic loan. That mixed history is normal Persian vocabulary, not an exception to memorize away.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **khodâ** — God
- *Read it:* خدا from the right edge
- *Connect:* modern **khodâ** ← Middle Persian *xwadây* “lord”

Before you move on

Which letter carries the final long â? (l.) Which vowel is heard but not written separately? (The short o.)
Source: Wiktionary: خدا.

5.2 حافظ — “guardian” or “protector”

Read خدا and say **khodâ**. Keep it separate: this lesson adds only the second word behind the farewell.

You’ll want to know first — one word

حافظ — *hâfez* — guardian, protector

Read ح ا ف ظ from right to left. ا carries long â. In contemporary Persian, final ظ is pronounced **z** here, so say *hâ-fez*, not an English *th* sound. The short *e* is part of the learned word and is normally unwritten.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Arabic **ḥāfiẓ** is an active participle from the root **ḥ-f-ẓ**, “guard, preserve.” Persian borrowed the word and uses its Persian pronunciation **hâfez**. Keep the useful meaning first; the root is a memory hook.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hâfez** — guardian, protector
- *Read it:* حافظ
- *Connect:* Arabic **ḥ-f-ẓ** — guard, preserve

Before you move on

What does **hâfez** contribute to the farewell? (The idea of guarding or protecting.)

Source: American Heritage Dictionary: *hafiz*.

5.3 خدا حافظ — goodbye

Retrieve **khodâ** and **hâfez** separately: “God” + “guardian.”
Now let them become one everyday social move.

The two words — put the known pieces together

خدا حافظ — *khodâ hâfez* — goodbye

Persian normally writes the two spoken pieces together. Start with خدا, add حافظ, and read the joined spelling خدا حافظ from the right edge. Keep the two meaning layers available underneath the complete form.

Grammar Lens — a complete wish without a full sentence

The expression carries the protective sense “God [be] guardian,” but everyday speakers use the whole formula simply as **goodbye**. No new verb is required for beginner production. It is a broadly polite, reliable way to end the short respectful interaction built in Chapters 1–4.

Your turn

- *Build:* **khodâ** + **hâfez**
- *Read it:* joined خدا حافظ
- *Use:* say it only when the interaction ends

Before you move on

When do you use **khodâ hâfez**? (At parting, not at the opening.)
Source: Persian Online: Greetings List.

5.4 Practice — open, check, and close

Without looking ahead, retrieve the expression for the beginning and the expression for the end. Do not add a new middle line.

The exchange — the complete interaction

A: سلام! چطور شما حال است؟ *Salâm! Hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?* B: ممنون خوبم. *Khubam, mamnun.* A: خدا حافظ. *Khodâ hâfez.* B: خدا حافظ. *Khodâ hâfez.*

Every line is already learned. **Salâm** opens; **khodâ hâfez** closes. The same farewell works for both voices, so no pronoun, agreement ending, or new register table is hiding inside the practice.

Your turn

- *Choose*: meeting begins → **salâm**
- *Choose*: interaction ends → **khodâ hâfez**
- *Run through*: both voices once with script, once without romanization

Before you move on

Run the full exchange once. If the final line stalls, return only to the assembled-farewell lesson rather than rereading the chapter.

Chapter 6

Name a Verb, Find Its Stem

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five core Persian verbs in their dictionary form, recognise the -tan/-dan ending that marks any Persian infinitive, and give the present stem that each verb carries beside it.

The five pairs run back to back from memory — budan, raftan/rav-, âmadan/â-, goftan/gu-, dânestan/dân- — with the infinitive ending named and the stem produced for each.

6.1 بودن — “to be,” and the ending every Persian verb wears

Chapter 4 ended on خوبم *khubam*, “I am well.” That **-am** carried “I am” with no verb beside it. This chapter names the verb it belongs to.

You’ll want to know first — one verb

بودن — *budan* — to be

Four letters, all of them already yours. From the right edge: ب *b*, و long *u*, د *d*, ن *n*. Persian و never joins to the letter on its left, so the word falls into two clumps, بو and دن — the same kind of break ل makes inside سلام.

Grammar Lens: how a Persian verb announces itself

English names a verb with a word in front of it: *to be, to go, to know*. Persian names it with an ending on the back. Every Persian infinitive — every one, with no list of exceptions — finishes in *-تن* *-tan* or *-دن* *-dan*.

بودن is *bu + dan*. Whenever a Persian word ends in *-tan* or *-dan*, you are holding a verb in its naming form.

Persian rewards you here: one set of personal endings serves every verb. What it asks instead is one extra fact per verb — the next lesson is about that fact.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

budan continues Middle Persian *būdan*, from the Indo-European root **bheu-*, “to grow, to become, to be.” English **be** and **been** are that root, worn smooth. So are German *bin*, Latin *fuī* “I was” — the ancestor of English **future** — and Sanskrit *bhavati*.

The resemblance runs through Persian’s plainest words: مادر *mâdar* is **mother**, پدر *pedar* is **father**, برادر *barâdar* is **brother**, دختر *dokhtar* is **daughter**, نام *nâm* is **name**. Nobody borrowed these; both languages inherited them.

One caution to carry through the chapter: lookalikes lie. Persian بد *bad* does mean “bad,” but its history and the English word’s are unconnected. A cousin has to be traced, not guessed.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **budan** — to be
- *Read it:* بودن from the right edge, in its two clumps
- *Name:* the ending that marks a Persian infinitive — **-tan / -dan**
- *Connect:* **budan** ← **bheu-* → English **be, been**
- *Retrieve:* the ending on خويم that already meant “I am”

Before you move on

How does a Persian verb announce that it is a verb? (It ends in *-tan* or *-dan*.) Which English word is **budan**? (**Be** — the same inherited

root.) Is Persian **bad** a cousin of English *bad*? (No; that one is coincidence.)

Source: Wiktionary: بودن.

6.2 رفتن — “to go,” and the second form that travels with it

Retrieve the Persian for “to be,” and the ending that marked it as a verb. That ending returns here, on a word that brings the extra fact Persian asks of you.

You’ll want to know first — one verb

رفتن — *raftan* — to go

From the right edge: ر *r*, ف *f*, ت *t*, ن *n* — all four familiar, ر from چطور *chetor* and ف from حافظ *hâfez*. ر does not join leftward, so it stands alone and رفتن follows as one run. The ending is the *-tan* you met on بودن.

Grammar Lens: the second fact every Persian verb carries

Persian keeps two forms for each verb, and you learn them as a pair. The first is the infinitive, رفتن *raftan*. Strip its *-an* and you have رفت *raft*, the **past stem**; everything about yesterday is built on that. The second is the **present stem**, and it cannot be predicted from the infinitive. For *raftan* it is رو *rav*. Everything about now is built on *rav*: *mi-ravam* “I go,” *mi-ravad* “she goes.” So the fact to store is not *raftan* alone but **raftan** → **rav-**, said in one breath. Get the pair and the whole verb opens: the endings that follow a stem are the same for every Persian verb.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

رفتن *raftan* continues Middle Persian *raftan*; its deeper Indo-European ancestry is genuinely unsettled, so no English cousin is claimed for it here.

The split itself needs no excuse — English does the same thing. *Go* and *went* are two unrelated words sharing one verb; so are *be* and *was*. English calls that irregularity and buries it in a list. Persian makes it

the ordinary shape of a verb and says so up front.

رو *rav* is short: ر, then و, with no join between them. Say the pair aloud until it sounds like one item — *raftan, rav*.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **raftan** — to go
- *Say it:* the pair as one item — **raftan, rav**
- *Read it:* رفتن, then رو
- *Name:* the ending that made **raftan** an infinitive
- *Retrieve:* the Chapter 6 verb meaning “to be” — **budan**

Before you move on

Which two facts does a Persian verb ask you to store? (The infinitive and its present stem.) What is the pair for “to go”? (**Raftan, rav.**) Could *rav-* have been worked out from *raftan*? (No — which is why it is learned with the word.)

Source: Wiktionary: رفتن.

6.3 آمدن — “to come,” and an alef that wears a hat

Say the pair for “to go” as one item. Now expect the same two-part shape from every verb that follows, including this one, which travels in the opposite direction.

You’ll want to know first — one verb and one new shape

آمدن — *âmadan* — to come

The last three letters are old friends: م *m*, د *d*, ن *n*, and the *-dan* ending tells you at once that this is an infinitive. The first shape is new. Ā is plain l with a small wavy stroke over it, called *madde*, and it is what Persian writes when a word opens on long â. Plain l at the start of a word carries a short vowel — that is the l in اسم *esm*. The hat is the difference between *esm* and *âmadan*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

âmadan was built from a prefix **â-**, “toward,” and the very old verb root **gwem-*, “to go, to come.” In Old Iranian that gave a form like **â-gmata-*, “come toward”; the *g* wore away, the *m* survived, and Middle Persian **âmad** is what was left.

That root is one of the family’s great travellers. English kept it almost bare as **come**. Latin turned it into *venīre*, which English then borrowed back dozens of times over: **advent**, **adventure**, **convene**, **convenient**, **event**, **invent**, **avenue**, **revenue**, **prevent**, **souvenir**. Sanskrit has *gacchati*, “goes.” So *âmadan* and *come* are not lookalikes; they are the same word, four thousand years apart.

The present stem is $\bar{I} \hat{a}$ — a single letter — heard as *ây-* before an ending: *mī-âyam* “I come.” Store the pair as **âmadan**, **â-**. It comes from a different ancient root than the infinitive does, which is exactly why the two look nothing alike.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **âmadan** — to come
- *Say it:* the pair as one item — **âmadan**, **â-**
- *Read it:* آمدن, starting at the hatted alef
- *Connect:* **âmadan** $\leftarrow$ **gwem-* $\rightarrow$ English **come**, **advent**, **event**
- *Contrast:* **raftan**, **rav-** going out; **âmadan**, **â-** coming in

Before you move on

What does the little hat on $\bar{I} \hat{a}$ tell you? (The word opens on long **â**.) Which everyday English verb shares *âmadan*’s root? (**Come**.) And what is the pair for “to come”? (**Âmadan**, **â-**.)
Source: Wiktionary: آمدن.

6.4 گفتن — “to say,” written with a letter Arabic does not have

Say the pair for “to come.” Then hold the shape in mind: a name, and a present stem that has to be learned beside it. Here

is a third verb built the same way.

You'll want to know first — one verb and one new letter

گفتن — *goftan* — to say, to tell

Read from the right. The last three, ف *f*, ت *t*, ن *n*, close the word with the familiar *-tan*. The opening shape is گ *g*, called *gâf*: a long slanting stroke with a second slanting stroke laid above it.

Arabic has no *g*, so Persian made one. Persian adds four letters to the inherited Arabic set — پ *p*, چ *ch*, ژ *zh*, and گ *g* — and you have already read one of them, the چ inside چیست *chist*. Each is an Arabic letter with extra strokes: گ is the *k* shape wearing a second bar.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The present stem is گو *gu*: گ then و, no join between them. *Mi-guyam* is “I say.” Store the pair as **goftan, gu-**.

Now the part that makes the pair unforgettable. Persian has an ordinary, everyday word for “conversation”: گفتگو *goftogu*. Pull it apart and it is the past stem گفت *goft*, a linking *-o-* meaning “and,” and the present stem گو *gu*. A conversation is literally *said-and-say*. The two halves of the verb, sitting next to each other in a noun you can hear on any Iranian news broadcast.

The verb is old. Old Persian, the language of Darius’s cliff inscriptions, already had the root *gaub-*, “to say, to call oneself.” Outside the Iranian branch its relatives are not securely established, so no English cousin is claimed here — and English *gab* and *gossip*, which look tempting, come from somewhere else entirely.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **goftan** — to say
- *Say it*: the pair as one item — **goftan, gu-**
- *Read it*: گ, then گو, then گفتن
- *Build*: **goft** + *-o-* + **gu** → **goftogu**, conversation
- *Retrieve*: the pair for “to come” — **âmadan, â-**

Before you move on

Which letter opens گفتن, and why is it not in Arabic? (گ *gâf*; Arabic has no *g* sound.) What two pieces of the verb hide inside **goftogu**? (The past stem *goft* and the present stem *gu*.) Say the pair. (**Goftan**, **gu-**.)

Source: Wiktionary: گفتن.

6.5 دانستن — “to know,” and five pairs held together

Name the ending that marks a Persian infinitive. The last verb of the chapter wears it, and every letter in the word is one you can already read.

You’ll want to know first — one verb and its stem

دانستن — *dânestan* — **to know**

From the right: د *d*, | long â, ن *n*, س *s*, ت *t*, ن *n*. Nothing new to decode, which is a good place to be six lessons into a script.

The present stem is دان *dân*: *mi-dânam*, “I know.” The pair is **dânestan**, **dân-** — and this stem is one you can watch working. دانش *dânes̄h* is “knowledge”; add گاه *gâh*, “place,” and you get دانشگاه *dânes̄hgâh*, **university** — a knowledge-place, built straight off the stem.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dânestan belongs to the Indo-European root **gnō-*, “to know.” English inherited it three times over: **know**, and also **can** (originally “to know how”), **ken**, **cunning**, and **uncouth**, which is literally “un-known.” Latin’s *nōscere* sent English **notice**, **notion**, **note**, **recognise**, **cognition**, and **noble** — a noble person being a known one. Greek *gnōsis* gives **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, **agnostic**. Sanskrit has *jânâti*, “knows.” One honest footnote: specialists still argue about how this root arrived in Persian wearing a **d**, when its Iranian relatives usually show a *z* or *zh*. The membership in the family is standard; the road it took is disputed, and this book flags that rather than smoothing it over.

Persian’s other “know” is شناختن *shenâkhtan*, used for knowing a person rather than a fact. Its stem شناس *shenâs-* shows the same root more

plainly — it is the *gnos-* of *gnosis*, wearing Iranian clothes.
 And بودن *budan* has a present stem too: باش *bâsh-*. It waits for the chapter where the present tense arrives.

Your turn

- Say it: **dânestan**, **dân-** — to know
- Say it: **raftan**, **rav-** — to go
- Say it: **âmadan**, **â-** — to come
- Say it: **goftan**, **gu-** — to say
- Say it: **budan** — to be
- Build: **dân** → **dânesh** → **dâneshgâh**, university
- Connect: **dânestan** ← **gnō-* → English **know**, **can**, **diagnosis**

Before you move on

Which two things does a Persian verb ask you to store? (Its name in *-tan* or *-dan*, and its present stem.) Which English words share **dânestan**'s root? (**Know**, **can**, and the *gnosis* family.) Now run all five pairs once, out loud, without the page.

Source: Wiktionary: دانستن.

Chapter 7

Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say think, understand, read and write in Persian, give the present stem of each, and tell which of the three ways a Persian verb is built each one uses.

The chapter closes on neveshtan, nevis-, then runs its four verbs back to back — fekr kardan with kon-, fahmidan with fahm-, khândan with khân-, neveshtan with nevis- — and names which is a compound, which hands its stem over free, and which two had to be told. The five pairs from Chapter 6 run after them, so all nine are produced from memory in one sitting.

7.1 کردن فکر — “to think,” written as two words

Name the two facts every Persian verb has asked you to store. This one brings a third shape: it is spelled as two words, and only the second is the verb.

You’ll want to know first — one verb in two pieces

کردن فکر — *fekr kardan* — **to think**

The first word, فکر *fekr*, is a noun: “thought.” From the right — ف *f*, ک *k*, ر *r*.

The second, کردن *kardan*, is the verb, and it means **to do, to make**. Its ending is the *-dan* you have collected since بودن *budan*. Word for word, the phrase is *thought to-do*.

Grammar Lens: Persian asks less of you than you fear

Persian has **no grammatical gender**, so nothing has to agree. It has **no noun cases**: a noun keeps one shape everywhere. Its adjectives **never change**. And it has exactly **one** set of personal endings — *-am*, *-i*, *-ad*, *-im*, *-id*, *-and* — taken by every verb in the language.

What it asks instead is the present stem, and this: many of its commonest verbs are **two words**. A noun sits in front, and a plain verb behind it does the grammatical work. کردن *kardan* is the workhorse — put almost any noun in front of it and you have a verb. You met the same instinct in خوشوقتم *khoshvaghtam*, which welded *khosh*, “good,” to *vaqt*, “time.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The halves come from opposite ends of Persian’s history.

فکر *fekr* is a loan from Arabic فِكر *fikr*, “thought,” on the root *f-k-r*, and it takes Persian grammar completely.

کردن *kardan* is as Persian as a word gets: Old Persian *kar-*, “to do,” from the Indo-European root **k^wer-*, “to make.” That root gave Sanskrit *karoti*, “he does,” and *karman*, “deed” — which English borrowed outright as **karma**. English has no inherited cousin here, so that is a borrowing, not a family resemblance, and this book says which is which. The present stem is کن *kon*: *mi-konam*, “I do.” Store **kardan**, **kon-**, and note the opening ک *kâf* — the shape گ *gâf* is built from, as گفتن *goftan* wears it with a second bar.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **fekr kardan** — to think
- *Split*: **fekr**, thought — **kardan**, to do
- *Say it*: the pair as one item — **kardan**, **kon-**
- *Read it*: ک in کردن, then گ in گفتن — one bar apart
- *Retrieve*: the two words welded inside **khoshvaghtam**
- *Name*: the ending that marks **kardan** as an infinitive

Before you move on

Which half of **fekr kardan** is the verb, and what is its present stem? (**Kardan**; **kon-**.) Name two of the four things Persian does without. (Gender, cases, adjective agreement, a second set of endings.)
Source: Wiktionary: کردن.

7.2 فهمیدن — “to understand,” and the class that gives its stem away

Say the two words meaning “to think,” and which of them is the verb. Then say the pair for “to know.” This lesson adds the verb that sits between them.

You’ll want to know first — one verb, one word this time

فهمیدن — *fahmidan* — to understand

One word, not two. From the right: ف *f*, ه *h*, م *m*, ی long *i*, د *d*, ن *n*. The ی is the letter you first read inside چیست *chist*.

Persian keeps دانستن *dānestan* and فهمیدن *fahmidan* apart the way English keeps *know* and *understand* apart. *Dānestan* stores a fact; *fahmidan* grasps a point.

Grammar Lens: the one stem you never have to be told

Every verb so far handed you an unpredictable stem: *raftan* gave *rav-*, *goftan* gave *gu-*. Here is the relief.

When a Persian infinitive ends in -یدن *-idan*, its present stem is what is left once you take the *-idan* off. Nothing shifts. فهمیدن *fahmidan* minus *-idan* leaves فهم *fahm*: *mi-fahmam*, “I understand.” The pair is **fahmidan**, **fahm-**, and you could have worked it out yourself.

This is no small exception. **-idan** is the suffix Persian reaches for whenever it needs a new verb, so the predictable class is large and growing. The verbs that fight you are the old inherited ones.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

فهم *fahm* is Arabic — فَهْم, “understanding,” from the root *f-h-m*. Persian took the noun and did something Arabic would not: it glued a native

Persian suffix onto it and made a verb.

You have now watched Arabic words arrive three ways. وقت *vaqt*, inside *khoshvaghtam*, came as a noun and stayed one. حال *hâl* came as a noun and took Persian's own linking grammar. حافظ *hâfez* came as a participle and became a name. And فهم *fahm* was turned into a Persian verb outright.

Against all of them stands خوب *khub*, inherited Persian from the start, borrowed from nobody. Persian vocabulary is layered, and neither layer is less Persian than the other today.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **fahmidan** — to understand
- *Derive:* strip *-idan* from **fahmidan** → the stem **fahm-**
- *Contrast:* **dânestan** stores a fact; **fahmidan** grasps a point
- *Retrieve:* the pair for “to know” — **dânestan**, **dân-**
- *Name:* three Arabic arrivals — *vaqt*, *hâl*, *hâfez* — and one inherited word, *khub*
- *Read it:* the ی inside فهمیدن, the letter you first met in چیست

Before you move on

How do you get the present stem of any *-idan* verb? (Take the *-idan* off.) Which of Persian's layers did **fahm** arrive from, and which layer does **khub** belong to? (*Fahm* is Arabic; *khub* is inherited Persian.)

Source: Wiktionary: فهمیدن.

7.3 خواندن — “to read,” and a letter that is written but not said

Say the pair for “to understand,” and how you got its stem without being told. This verb is not so obliging — and its spelling hides something.

You'll want to know first — one verb with a silent letter

خواندن — *khândan* — to read

From the right: خ *kh*, و, | long â, ن *n*, د *d*, ن *n*. Six letters — but only five sounds. The و in second position is written and **not pronounced**. The word is *khândan*, never *khwândan*.

That خ opens خوب *khub*, “good,” where the و works as a vowel. Here it does nothing.

The silent و belongs to a small, closed set of words — always after خ, before |. Not a rule to apply, just words you recognize.

Grammar Lens: one verb, four English verbs

The present stem is خوان *khân* — same silent و, so *khân-*. *Mi-khânam*, “I read.” The pair is **khândan**, **khân-**.

Now the surprise. خواندن also means **to recite**, **to sing** and **to study**. English splits those jobs across separate words; Persian does not, and the reason is in the word’s history.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

khândan is from Proto-Iranian **hwanH-*, “to call,” from the Indo-European root **swenh₂-*, “**to sound**.” The four meanings become one idea: reading, reciting and singing all *make a text sound*. For most of history, reading was reading aloud.

Latin took the root as *sonus*, which English borrowed over and over: **sound**, **sonic**, **resonate**, **consonant**, **sonata**. Sanskrit has *svanati*, “it sounds.” And English inherited one word directly, without Latin’s help — **swan**, most likely “the sounding one.”

The silent و is a fossil of this: the Iranian root began *hw-*, and Persian spelled the cluster long after it stopped saying it. خدا *khodâ* comes from the same *xw-* family, continuing Middle Persian *xwadây* — gone from both mouths, surviving in one spelling.

One contrast to fix: the long â here is plain | because it sits inside the word. When a word *opens* on long â, Persian writes Ā with its hat, as آمدن *âmadan* does.

Your turn

- Say it: **khândan** — to read

- *Say it:* the pair as one item — **khândan, khân-**
- *Read it:* خواندن, sounding the خ and skipping the و
- *List:* the four jobs of one verb — read, recite, sing, study
- *Connect:* **khândan** ← **swenh*₂- → English **sound, swan**
- *Contrast:* ɪ inside a word, Ī when a word opens on long â

Before you move on

How many letters does خواندن have, and how many sounds? (Six and five.) Which four English verbs does it cover, and why those four together? (Read, recite, sing, study — its root means *to sound*.)
Source: Wiktionary: خواندن.

7.4 نوشتن — “to write,” and four verbs of the mind held together

Say the pair for “to read,” and name the letter in it that is written but never said. Its natural partner closes this chapter.

You’ll want to know first — one verb and its stem

نوشتن — *neveshtan* — **to write**

From the right: ن *n*, و *v*, ش *sh*, ت *t*, ن *n*. Here the و *is* pronounced — a plain consonant *v* — the exact contrast the last lesson set up.

The present stem is نویس *nevis*: *mi-nevisam*, “I write.” The pair is **neveshtan, nevis-**, as unpredictable as *raftan, rav-* was. Name the price plainly: **the stem of an inherited verb cannot be worked out, so it is learned in the same breath as the infinitive.**

Watch the stem earn its keep: نویس *nevis-* plus *-ande* gives نویسنده *nevisande*, “**writer**.” The stem, not the infinitive, is what Persian builds on.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

neveshtan is an Old Persian compound: **ni-**, “down,” plus the root **paiš-*, “to adorn, to mark, to paint.” To write was to *paint something down* — a verb Darius had carved into a cliff at Behistun.

The root is Indo-European **peyk-*, “to cut, to mark, to paint.” Latin made it *pingere*, and English has borrowed from that ever since: **paint**, **picture**, **pigment**, **depict**. So *neveshtan* and *picture* are one root, one branch writing, the other painting.

Trace the *p* if you like a puzzle: it softened to *b* in Middle Persian *nibištan*, then to the *v* in *nevis-*.

Grammar Lens: what this chapter has actually given you

Four verbs, three ways a Persian verb can be built.

فکر کردن *fekr kardan* is a **compound**: noun plus *kardan*. فهمیدن *fahmidan* is a **-idan verb**, stem free. خواندن *khândan* and نوشتن *neveshtan* are **inherited verbs**, stems you must be told.

Three shapes, one set of personal endings for all of them — the whole verb system in outline.

Your turn

Run the chapter’s four, then the five that came before, without the page.

- *Say it*: **fekr kardan** — to think; **kardan, kon-**
- *Say it*: **fahmidan, fahm-** — to understand
- *Say it*: **khândan, khân-** — to read
- *Say it*: **neveshtan, nevis-** — to write
- *Say it*: **budan** — to be; **raftan, rav-**; **âmadan, â-**; **goftan, gu-**; **dânestan, dân-**
- *Build*: **nevis** + *-ande* → **nevisande**, writer
- *Connect*: **neveshtan** ← **peyk-* → English **paint, picture**
- *Name*: the English cousins of **budan** and **dânestan** — **be** and **know**

Before you move on

Which of this chapter’s four verbs is a compound, and which one hands you its stem for free? (**Fekr kardan**; **fahmidan**.) What did *neveshtan* originally mean? (To paint down.) Now say all nine pairs

you hold, in any order.

Source: Wiktionary: نوشتن.

Chapter 8

Taking, Asking, Helping, Loving

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say take, ask, help and love in Persian, give the present stem where a verb has one, and sort all thirteen verbs I hold into compounds, -idan verbs and inherited verbs.

The chapter closes on dust dâshtan — to have as friend — and its dâr-stem, then runs all thirteen verbs the track has taught: this chapter’s four, Chapter 7’s four, and Chapter 6’s five, each with its stem, sorted into the three shapes a Persian verb can take.

8.1 گرفتن — “to take,” and a cousin you can hear

Say the pair for “to write.” Then get ready for a Persian verb whose English relative you will recognize the moment you hear it.

You’ll want to know first — one verb and its stem

گرفتن — *gereftan* — **to take**

From the right: گ *g*, ر *r*, ف *f*, ت *t*, ن *n*. The opening shape is گ *gâf*, the letter Persian added because Arabic has no *g* — the same one that opens گفتن *goftan*. Neither گ nor ر joins leftward, so the word arrives in three small pieces and closes on the familiar *-tan*.

The present stem is گیر *gir*: *mi-giram*, “I take.” The pair is **gereftan, gir-** — inherited, and so unpredictable, exactly as promised.

Persian uses it widely: to take, to get, to catch, to hold, to seize. It is a hand closing around something.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gereftan continues Middle Persian *griftan*, from Old Persian *grab-*, “to seize,” from the Indo-European root **g^hrebh₂-*, “to grab, to seize.”

Say *gir-* and *grip* one after the other. Say *gereftan* and *grab*. That is not a coincidence and it is not a loan in either direction — English and Persian both inherited the word from a common ancestor, and four thousand years later the consonants *g-r-b* are still sitting in both. English kept **grab**, **grip**, **grasp**, **grobe** and **gripe**; German kept *greifen*; Sanskrit has *grhṇāti*, “he seizes”; Russian has *grabit’*, “to rob.”

Collect the evidence you already hold. بودن *budan* is English **be**. تو *to* is English **thou** — the old familiar you, which English has nearly retired and Persian uses daily. Persian is not a distant relative of English in an unfamiliar script; it is a cousin.

Persian has repaid the family too. English **bazaar**, **caravan**, **khaki**, **pyjama**, **lemon**, **spinach** and **paradise** all came from Persian — the last of them from Old Persian *paridaida*, “a walled garden.”

Your turn

- *Say it:* **gereftan** — to take
- *Say it:* the pair as one item — **gereftan**, **gir-**
- *Read it:* گ opening گرفتن, then گ opening گفتن
- *Connect:* **gir-** → English **grip**; **gereftan** → English **grab**
- *Retrieve:* two cousins you already hold — **budan** is **be**, **to** is **thou**
- *Name:* three English words Persian gave away — **bazaar**, **khaki**, **paradise**

Before you move on

Which English verbs are **gereftan**’s own relatives? (**Grab**, **grip**, **grasp**.) Did English borrow it from Persian? (No — both inherited it.) Say the pair once more. (**Gereftan**, **gir-**.)

Source: Wiktionary: گرفتن.

8.2 پرسیدن — “to ask,” and the questions you could already ask

Say the pair for “to take.” Then put the respectful name question you have had since Chapter 3. You have been asking without owning the verb.

You’ll want to know first — one verb that behaves

پرسیدن — *porsidan* — to ask

From the right: پ *p*, ر *r*, س *s*, ی long *i*, د *d*, ن *n*. The opening پ *pe* is another letter Persian added — a ب *b* shape with three dots beneath instead of one.

Now the ending: -یدن *-idan*. Strip it, and the present stem remains: پرس *pors*. *Mi-porsam*, “I ask.” The pair is **porsidan**, **pors-** — the same free ride فهمیدن *fahmidan* gave you.

Grammar Lens: asking a question and asking a person

Two chapters ago you learned to *put* a question — شما اسم چیست؟ *esm-e shomâ chist?*, چطور شما حال است؟ *hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?* Both work by word order and a question word, with no verb meaning “ask” in them. That is the ordinary case, as in English: you do not say “I ask you what your name is,” you just ask it. پرسیدن is for *talking about* the asking. The noun from the same stem is پرسش *porsesh*, “a question”: stem plus -ش *-esh*, the machine that turned دان *dân-* into دانش *dânes*h, “knowledge.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

porsidan continues Middle Persian *pursīdan*, from Old Persian *pars-* — a word Darius used on stone — and beyond that the Indo-European root **prek-*, “to ask.” Sanskrit has *pr̥cchati*; German still says *fragen*. English is the interesting case. It **had** this root and lost it: Old English *frīgnan*, “to ask,” died out. Then English borrowed the root back from Latin, which had turned it into *precārī*, “to pray.” So English says **pray**, **prayer**, **precarious** — “held by prayer,” and so uncertain — and **deprecate**. A root the language once owned now survives only as loans.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **porsidan** — to ask
- *Derive:* strip *-idan* → the stem **pors-**
- *Pair:* **porsidan**, **pors-** beside **fahmidan**, **fahm-** — both free
- *Contrast:* **gereftan**, **gir-** had to be told; these two did not
- *Build:* **pors** + *-esh* → **porsesh**, a question
- *Connect:* **porsidan** ← **prek-* → English **pray**, **precarious**

Before you move on

Which two verbs so far gave you their stems for free, and what do they have in common? (**Fahmidan** and **porsidan** — both end in *-idan*.) Why does English say **pray** rather than an inherited word here? (It lost its own and borrowed the root back from Latin.)

Source: Wiktionary: پرسیدن.

8.3 کردن کمک — “to help,” and the machine on its second run

Say the pair for “to ask.” Then the two words meaning “to think,” and which half of them is the verb. That half is about to do the same job twice over.

You’ll want to know first — one verb in two pieces, once more

کردن کمک — *komak kardan* — **to help**

Two words, and you already know the second one. کمک *komak* is a noun, “help, assistance.” From the right: ک *k*, م *m*, ک *k* — the same *kâf* twice, once joined and once standing free at the word’s end.

Behind it sits کردن *kardan*, doing exactly what it did in فکر کردن *fekr kardan*. Noun in front, *kardan* behind, and the pair is a verb. Its present stem is still کن *kon-*: *komak mi-konam*, “I help.”

This is the point of the pattern. You are not learning a second verb; you are learning a second **noun** and dropping it into a slot you already own.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

کمک *komak* is neither inherited Persian nor Arabic. It came from **Turkic** — Azerbaijani *kömək*, “help,” from Proto-Turkic **kömek*. Turkic and Persian have been neighbours for a thousand years, and words crossed both ways.

So everyday Persian vocabulary holds three layers, and you have a word from each. خوب *khub*, “good,” is **inherited** Iranian. وقت *vaqt*, “time,” inside *khoshvaghtam*, is **Arabic**. کمک *komak* is **Turkic**. All three are ordinary Persian words today, and none is more Persian than the others. The verb half is the oldest thing here: کردن *kardan* on the Indo-European root **k^wer-*, “to make.” A Turkic noun and an Indo-European verb in one phrase — Persian’s history in three syllables.

One script note: the ک *kâf* opening *komak* is the shape گ *gâf* is built from, one bar apart.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **komak kardan** — to help
- *Split:* **komak**, help — **kardan**, to do
- *Match:* **fekr kardan** and **komak kardan** — one machine, two nouns
- *Say it:* the stem still in place — **kardan**, **kon-**
- *Sort:* **khub** inherited, **vaqt** Arabic, **komak** Turkic
- *Retrieve:* the two words welded inside **khoshvaghtam**
- *Read it:* ک in کمک, then گ — one bar apart

Before you move on

Which half of **komak kardan** did you already know? (**Kardan**.) Which of Persian’s three vocabulary layers did **komak** come from? (Turkic.) Name a word from each of the other two. (**Khub**, inherited; **vaqt**, Arabic.)
Source: Wiktionary: کمک.

8.4 داشتن دوست — “to love,” which Persian says as “to have as friend”

Say the two words meaning “to help,” and the pair for “to ask.”

This last verb is a compound too — but not with *kardan*.

You’ll want to know first — one verb in two pieces, a new second half

داشتن دوست — *dust dâshtan* — to like, to love

دوست *dust* is a noun: **friend**. From the right, د *d*, و long *u*, س *s*, ت *t*.

داشتن *dâshtan* is the verb, **to have, to hold**. Its present stem is دار *dâr*: the pair is **dâshtan, dâr-**.

So *dust dâshtan* is, word for word, **to have as friend**. *Dust dâram* is “I love” — literally “I hold [it] a friend,” built out of friendship rather than passion.

Notice what changed. کردن *kardan* made a noun into a *doing*. داشتن *dâshtan* makes it a *holding*. Two light verbs, one pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Both halves are old, and both have English relatives.

دوست *dust* goes back through Old Persian *dauštā* to the Indo-European root **ǵews-*, “to taste, to choose.” A friend is *the one chosen*. English inherited it directly as **choose**; Latin took it as *gustus*, “taste,” giving English **gusto** and **disgust**.

داشتن *dâshtan* continues Old Persian *dāraya-*, “to hold,” from **d^her-*. English has no inherited cousin here, but the root fills its borrowings: Latin *firmitas*, “held fast,” gave **firm**; Greek *thronos* gave **throne**; Sanskrit built *dharma*, “that which holds the world together.”

So Persian builds “I love you” from *choose* and *hold*.

Grammar Lens: what the two chapters add up to

Thirteen verbs now, and every one fits one of three shapes.

Compounds — *fekr kardan, komak kardan, dust dâshtan*: noun plus light verb. **-idan verbs** — *fahmidan, porsidan*: stem free. **Inherited verbs** — *budan, raftan, âmadan, goftan, dânestan, khândan, neveshtan, gereftan*: stem told, never guessed.

Behind all three: one infinitive ending; one set of personal endings; no

gender, no cases, no agreement. The hard part of Persian is a list of stems.

Your turn

All thirteen, from memory.

- *Say it:* **gereftan**, gir-; **porsidan**, pors-; **komak kardan**; **dust dâshtan**, dâr-
- *Say it:* **fekr kardan**, kon-; **fahmidan**, fahm-; **khândan**, khân-; **neveshtan**, nevis-
- *Say it:* **budan**; **raftan**, rav-; **âmadan**, â-; **goftan**, gu-; **dânestan**, dâ-
- *Split:* **dust**, friend — **dâshtan**, to hold
- *Sort:* which three are compounds, which two are *-idan*, which eight are inherited
- *Connect:* **dust** ← **ǵews-* → English **choose**; **gereftan** → **grab**; **neveshtan** → **paint**

Before you move on

What does *dust dâshtan* say word for word? (To have as friend.) Which light verb makes a *doing*, and which makes a *holding*? (**Kardan**; **dâshtan**.) Now name all thirteen, with a stem for each that has one.

Source: Wiktionary: داشتن دوست.

Pronunciation & Script Reference

A **reference**, not a chapter. Look up a sound when a lesson names it; do not memorize this page first. The lessons introduce Persian script inside language the learner can already understand, one word-sized pattern at a time.

This track uses a learner romanization: **â** marks long *a*; **u** marks the long vowel in *mamnun*. Romanization is temporary scaffolding. Train your eye on the Persian form and gradually cover the Latin line.

The script in three facts

1. **Read right to left (rtl)**. Words and sentences begin at the right edge.
2. **Most letters join**, and their shape responds to position. Some letters do not connect leftward to the next letter. In سلام, ل creates the visible break before final م.
3. **Short vowels are normally unwritten** (**short-vowels-unwritten**). Learn the vowel pattern with the word. The long vowels are represented with ا *â*, و *u*, and ی *i*.

Persian has no uppercase/lowercase distinction. Its alphabet adds پ *p*, چ *ch*, ژ *zh*, and گ *g* to the inherited Arabic inventory; the lessons will introduce them only when a useful word needs them.

Sound ids used by the starter lessons

- **Sound id: rtl**
What to do: start at the right edge and follow the word leftward
First anchor: سلام *salâm*

- **Sound id: long-a**
What to do: hold ا as a steady *â*, near the vowel in “father”
First anchor: سلام *salâm*
- **Sound id: long-u**
What to do: hold و as *u*, near “oo” in “food,” without an English off-glide
First anchor: ممنون *mamnun*
- **Sound id: long-i**
What to do: hold ی as long *i* in the learned word
First anchor: چیست *chist*
- **Sound id: short-vowels-unwritten**
What to do: supply learned *a*, *e*, or *o* even when no separate vowel letter appears
First anchor: به *bale*, نه *na*
- **Sound id: ezafe-e**
What to do: say a light linking *-e* after a noun before its owner or description; ordinary text often leaves it unmarked
First anchor: من اسم *esm-e man*
- **Sound id: sh**
What to do: read three-dotted ش as *sh*
First anchor: شما *shomâ*
- **Sound id: persian-che**
What to do: read Persian چ as *ch*
First anchor: چیست *chist*
- **Sound id: kh**
What to do: make خ farther back than English *h*; a gentle approximation is acceptable first
First anchor: خوب *khub*
- **Sound id: gh**
What to do: use the modern Iranian Persian voiced back-of-the-mouth sound for غ
First anchor: خوشوقتم *khoshvaghtam*
- **Sound id: vav-o**
What to do: let و carry the learned *o* value in this word
First anchor: چطور *chetor*

- **Sound id:** persian-question-mark
What to do: recognize ؟ at the left end of a right-to-left question
First anchor: چیست؟ شما اسم
- **Sound id:** alef-madde
What to do: read آ — alef under a wavy *madde* — as a word-initial long *â*
First anchor: آمدن *âmadan*
- **Sound id:** persian-gaf
What to do: read گ *gâf* as English *g* in “go”; it is a Persian addition to the Arabic set
First anchor: گفتن *goftan*
- **Sound id:** persian-pe
What to do: read پ *pe* as English *p*; a ب shape with three dots beneath, and the third of Persian’s four additions
First anchor: پرسیدن *porsidan*
- **Sound id:** silent-vav
What to do: after خ and before ل, leave و unpronounced — it is written, never said
First anchor: خواندن *khândan*

Read the current word before the whole alphabet

- سلام gives م ا ل س, right-to-left direction, joining, and long *â*.
- ممنون reuses م, adds و ن, and assigns و its long-*u* job in this word.
- به and نه make the missing short vowels visible by contrast: the spelling supplies a consonantal frame; the learned word supplies *a/e*.
- من اسم ... است recombines familiar letters and adds one spoken grammar cue, ezafe -e. The cue is often heard but not printed.
- شما, چیست, and خوشوقتم add *sh*, Persian چ, and the back sounds in خ/غ only inside the name exchange.
- چطور است؟ چطور شما حال reuses ezafe and the Persian question mark; چطور gives و its learned *o* value, while خوبم returns to long-*u* و.
- خدا reuses خ and long-*â* ا; حافظ adds a clear initial *h* and a final ظ pronounced *z* in modern Persian. The complete farewell is normally joined in Persian as خدا حافظ.

- بودن, رفتن, and دانستن need no new letters at all; the verb chapter adds only آ (alef wearing a *madde*, for a word opening on long *â*) inside آمدن, and گ *gâf* inside گفتن — the second of the four Persian additions پ چ ژ گ the learner has now met.

One spelling symbol can do more than one job in later words—especially و and ی—so read from the word and context rather than assigning each shape one English value forever.

Sources

- Persian Online: The Writing System
- Persian Online: Connecting Characters
- Persian Online: Vowels

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

آمدن *âmadan*

to come — with the hat-wearing alef and a root English kept as *come*

Introduced in Chapter 6.

بله *bale*

yes

Introduced in Chapter 1.

بودن *budan*

to be — and the ending every Persian verb wears

Introduced in Chapter 6.

چطور *chetor*

how; in what manner

Introduced in Chapter 4.

چیست *chist*

what is?

Introduced in Chapter 3.

دانستن *dânestan*

to know — the chapter's clearest cousin, and the place all five pairs come back

Introduced in Chapter 6.

داشتن دوست *dust dâshtan*

to like, to love — “to have as friend,” and the place all thirteen verbs run together

Introduced in Chapter 8.

من اسم ... است *esm-e man ... ast*

my name is ...

Introduced in Chapter 2.

شما اسم چیست؟ *esm-e shomâ chist?*

What is your name? (respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

فهمیدن *fahmidan*

to understand — and the one Persian verb class whose stem you can predict

Introduced in Chapter 7.

کردن فکر *fekr kardan*

to think — two words bolted into one verb, and the pattern that builds hundreds more

Introduced in Chapter 7.

گرفتن *gereftan*

to take — and the clearest English cousin in this book

Introduced in Chapter 8.

گفتن *goftan*

to say — and the Persian-only letter گ that starts it

Introduced in Chapter 6.

حافظ *hâfez*

guardian, protector — the Arabic-rooted half of the farewell

Introduced in Chapter 5.

حال *hâl*

state, condition — the state in “How are you?”

Introduced in Chapter 4.

است؟ چطور شما حال *hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?*

How are you? (careful, respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

خواندن *khândan*

to read — and to recite, and to sing, because all three are sounding

Introduced in Chapter 7.

خدا *khodâ*

God — the inherited Persian half of the standard farewell

Introduced in Chapter 5.

خداحافظ *khodâ hâfez*

goodbye — the standard Persian farewell

Introduced in Chapter 5.

خوشوقتم *khoshvaghtam*

pleased to meet you

Introduced in Chapter 3.

خوب *khub*

good, well

Introduced in Chapter 4.

ممنون خوبم، *khubam, mamnun*

I am well, thank you

Introduced in Chapter 4.

کردن کمک *komak kardan*

to help — the compound pattern proving itself, and a third layer in the vocabulary

Introduced in Chapter 8.

ممنون *mamnun*

thank you / grateful

Introduced in Chapter 1.

نه *na*

no

Introduced in Chapter 1.

نوشتن *neveshtan*

to write — the chapter's last pair, and the place all four run together

Introduced in Chapter 7.

پرسیدن *porsidan*

to ask — the verb behind a question you have been asking since Chapter 3

Introduced in Chapter 8.

رفتن *raftan*

to go — the verb that shows why every Persian verb comes in two pieces

Introduced in Chapter 6.

سلام *salâm*

hello / peace

Introduced in Chapter 1.

شما / تو *shomâ / to*

you — respectful or plural / familiar singular

Introduced in Chapter 3.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 2

2.1 من اسم است ... — *my name is ...*

Type the careful Persian sentence 'My name is Sara.'

Chapter 3

3.1 تو / شما — *two relationships inside "you"*

Type the Persian 'you' safest in a first meeting.

3.2 چیست — *"what is?" in one joined word*

Join Persian chi + ast into the careful form 'what is?.'

3.3 شما اسم چیست؟ — *ask a name respectfully*

Type the respectful Persian question 'What is your name?'

3.4 خوشوقتم — *pleased to meet you*

Type the Persian response 'Pleased to meet you.'

3.5 Practice — *a complete Persian name exchange*

After someone asks شما اسم چیست؟, type the careful Persian answer using Sara.

Chapter 4

4.1 حال — *the "state" in a wellbeing question*

Type the Persian word meaning 'state' or 'condition'.

4.2 چطور — *"how?" one layer at a time*

Type the Persian question word meaning 'how?.'

4.3 است؟ چطور شما حال — *ask “How are you?” respectfully*

Type the careful respectful Persian question ‘How are you?’.

4.4 خوب — *“good” and “well”*

Type the Persian word meaning ‘good’ or ‘well’.

4.5 ممنون خوبم، — *“I am well, thank you”*

Reply in Persian: ‘I am well, thank you.’

4.6 Practice — *a Persian wellbeing exchange*

After است؟ چطور شما حال, type the polite Persian reply.

Chapter 5

5.1 خدا — *the Persian half of a farewell*

Type the Persian word *khodâ*, meaning ‘God’.

5.2 حافظ — *“guardian” or “protector”*

Type the Persian word *hâfez*, meaning ‘guardian’ or ‘protector’.

5.3 خداحافظ — *goodbye*

Type the standard Persian expression for ‘goodbye’.

5.4 Practice — *open, check, and close*

The short Persian interaction is ending. Type the final expression.

Chapter 6

6.1 بودن — *“to be,” and the ending every Persian verb wears*

Type the Persian verb meaning ‘to be’.

6.2 رفتن — *“to go,” and the second form that travels with it*

Give the present stem that goes with رفتن (*raftan*).

6.3 آمدن — *“to come,” and an alef that wears a hat*

Type the Persian verb meaning ‘to come’.

6.4 گفتن — *“to say,” written with a letter Arabic does not have*

Give the present stem that goes with گفتن (*goftan*).

6.5 دانستن — *“to know,” and five pairs held together*

Give the present stem that goes with دانستن (*dânestan*).

Chapter 7

7.1 کردن فکر — “to think,” written as two words

Type the two Persian words that together mean ‘to think’.

7.2 فهمیدن — “to understand,” and the class that gives its stem away

Give the present stem that goes with فهمیدن (fahmidan).

7.3 خواندن — “to read,” and a letter that is written but not said

In خواندن, which written letter is not pronounced?

7.4 نوشتن — “to write,” and four verbs of the mind held together

Give the present stem that goes with نوشتن (neveshtan).

Chapter 8

8.1 گرفتن — “to take,” and a cousin you can hear

Give the present stem that goes with گرفتن (gereftan).

8.2 پرسیدن — “to ask,” and the questions you could already ask

Give the present stem that goes with پرسیدن (porsidan).

8.3 کردن کمک — “to help,” and the machine on its second run

Type the two Persian words that together mean ‘to help’.

8.4 داشتن دوست — “to love,” which Persian says as “to have as friend”

Type the two Persian words that together mean ‘to love’.

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 2

2.1 من اسم است ... — *my name is ...*

Answer: است سارا من اسم

Also accepted: esm-e man Sara ast; esm-e man Sârâ ast

Chapter 3

3.1 تو / شما — *two relationships inside “you”*

Answer: شما

Also accepted: shoma; shomâ; shomâ

3.2 چیست — *“what is?” in one joined word*

Answer: چیست

Also accepted: chist; chîst

3.3 چیست؟ شما اسم — *ask a name respectfully*

Answer: چیست؟ شما اسم

Also accepted: چیست شما اسم; esm-e shoma chist; esm-e shomâ chist

3.4 خوشوقتم — *pleased to meet you*

Answer: خوشوقتم

Also accepted: khoshvaghtam; khoshvaqtam

3.5 Practice — *a complete Persian name exchange*

Answer: است سارا من اسم

Also accepted: esm-e man Sara ast; esm-e man Sârâ ast

Chapter 4

4.1 حال — *the “state” in a wellbeing question*

Answer: حال

Also accepted: hal; hâl; hāl

4.2 چطور — *“how?” one layer at a time*

Answer: چطور

Also accepted: chetor; chetowr

4.3 است؟ چطور شما حال — *ask “How are you?” respectfully*

Answer: است؟ چطور شما حال

Also accepted: است؟ چطور شما حال; hal-e shoma chetor ast; hâl-e shomâ chetor ast

4.4 خوب — *“good” and “well”*

Answer: خوب

Also accepted: khub; khûb; khoob

4.5 ممنون خوبم، — *“I am well, thank you”*

Answer: ممنون خوبم،

Also accepted: ممنون خوبم; khubam mamnun; khûbam mamnûn

4.6 Practice — *a Persian wellbeing exchange*

Answer: ممنون خوبم،

Also accepted: ممنون خوبم; khubam mamnun; khûbam mamnûn

Chapter 5

5.1 خدا — *the Persian half of a farewell*

Answer: خدا

Also accepted: khoda; khodâ; xodâ; xoda

5.2 حافظ — *“guardian” or “protector”*

Answer: حافظ

Also accepted: hafez; hâfez; hâfez; hafiz

5.3 خداحافظ — *goodbye*

Answer: خداحافظ

Also accepted: khodahafez; khoda hafez; khodâ hâfez; khodâ hâfez; xodâhâfez

5.4 Practice — *open, check, and close*

Answer: خداحافظ

Also accepted: khodahafez; khoda hafez; khodâ hâfez; khodâ hâfez

Chapter 6

6.1 بودن — *“to be,” and the ending every Persian verb wears*

Answer: بودن

Also accepted: budan; būdan

6.2 رفتن — “to go,” and the second form that travels with it

Answer: رو

Also accepted: rav; raw; rav-; ro

6.3 آمدن — “to come,” and an alef that wears a hat

Answer: آمدن

Also accepted: amadan; âmadan; āmadan

6.4 گفتن — “to say,” written with a letter Arabic does not have

Answer: گو

Also accepted: gu; gu-; gū; goo

6.5 دانستن — “to know,” and five pairs held together

Answer: دان

Also accepted: dan; dân; dān; dan-

Chapter 7

7.1 کردن فکر — “to think,” written as two words

Answer: کردن فکر

Also accepted: fekr kardan; fikr kardan; fekr-kardan

7.2 فهمیدن — “to understand,” and the class that gives its stem away

Answer: فهم

Also accepted: fahm; fahm-; feh

7.3 خواندن — “to read,” and a letter that is written but not said

Answer: و

Also accepted: vav; waw; v; the vav

7.4 نوشتن — “to write,” and four verbs of the mind held together

Answer: نویس

Also accepted: nevis; nevis-; nivis; navis

Chapter 8

8.1 گرفتن — “to take,” and a cousin you can hear

Answer: گیر

Also accepted: gir; gir-; gīr; geer

8.2 پرسیدن — “to ask,” and the questions you could already ask

Answer: پرس

Also accepted: pors; pors-; purs; pursh

8.3 کردن کمک — “to help,” and the machine on its second run

Answer: کردن کمک

Also accepted: komak kardan; komak-kardan; kumak kardan

8.4 داشتن دوست — “to love,” which Persian says as “to have as friend”

Answer: داشتن دوست

Also accepted: dust dashtan; dust dāshtan; dost dashtan; doost dashtan; dūst dāstan

A note on sources

Script descriptions follow the University of Texas at Austin Persian Online writing-system materials; its open greetings vocabulary grounds the Chapter 4 wellbeing forms and the Chapter 5 farewell.

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I

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pleased to meet you خوشوقتم (khoshvaghtam)

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to understand — and the one Persian verb class whose stem you**can predict** فهمیدن (fahmidan)

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to write — the chapter's last pair, and the place all four run together نوشتن (neveshtan)

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W

what is? چیست (chist)

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What is your name? (respectful) چیست؟ شما اسم (esm-e shomâ chist?)

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Y

yes بله (bale)

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you — respectful or plural / familiar singular شما / تو (shomâ / to)

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